

A FAITHFUL PATH COMMUNITY GUIDE

The Christian Spiritual Reset

*A 3-Day Guided Retreat to Overcome Burnout,
Hear God Clearly, and Renew Your Faith*

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FAITHFUL PATH COMMUNITY

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CHAPTER 9

Creating a Digital Boundary

Of the four ordinary questions from Chapter 6, the phone is one of the factors most likely to determine whether your retreat remains protected. You can have three protected days and a good location and still spend them checking. This chapter is about drawing a boundary you can actually keep, one that removes the noise without removing your access to help.

I want to say at the outset that this is not an anti-technology chapter. Your phone will carry the Bible, the map to your location, the number of your support person, and the means of calling for help. The goal is not to reject the device. It is to stop it from being the centre of your attention for a few days, so that something else can be.

Why it matters more than it seems

Most of us underestimate how much of our inner life is now shaped by a screen. The phone is the first thing many people touch in the morning and the last thing at night. It fills every gap: the queue, the lift, the two minutes before a meeting, the moment of boredom, the moment of discomfort. Those gaps can become places where thoughts surface, spontaneous prayer begins, and a person notices how they actually feel. Constant digital input makes such moments less available.

A retreat is, in large part, the deliberate reopening of those gaps. That is why silence is so central to the sessions ahead, and it is why, for many readers, the phone will be the most persistent avoidable threat to sustained attention. Every time you reach for it, you close the gap again.

Paul was addressing matters very different from digital technology when he wrote in **1 Corinthians 6:12**, "All things are lawful for me, but not all things are helpful. All things are lawful for me, but I will not be dominated by anything." Yet the principle invites a useful question: has something permissible gained more control over my attention than I intended? If the thought of turning the phone off produces something close to anxiety, that is worth noticing, not as a reason for shame but as information about what has been holding your attention.

And there is Martha. In **Luke 10:38–42**, Jesus visits the home of Martha and Mary. Mary sits at his feet and listens. Martha is "distracted with much serving," and when she complains, Jesus answers gently: "Martha, Martha, you are anxious and troubled about many things, but one thing is necessary." Martha's situation was not about technology, and her service was not the problem; the problem was distraction in that moment. But her story gives us a helpful picture of good and legitimate activity crowding out attentive presence. A phone can do something similar during a retreat.

What the boundary is for, and what it is not for

The boundary has one purpose: to protect your attention for God during the time you have set aside. It is not a test of willpower, a spiritual fast to be proud of, or a way of proving anything to anyone. If you slip and check something, you have not failed; you have noticed, and you can put it down again.

The boundary is also not a boundary against help. Chapter 5 was clear that emergency calling should remain available, and Chapter 6 asked you to keep reception where you can. Choose the arrangement that provides necessary safety without feeding repeated checking. Some readers will rest better with one scheduled check. Others will rest better knowing that a designated contact can call through at any time.

Two arrangements

There are two fundamentally different ways to do this, and you need to choose one, because they do not combine. A phone in airplane mode cannot ordinarily receive a call, so "airplane mode with an emergency channel" is not an arrangement at all.

Arrangement	Can calls reach you?	Best for
Focus or Do Not Disturb with selected contacts	Yes	Parents, caregivers, anyone with safety needs
Airplane mode with scheduled checks	No, except during checks	Readers who need deep separation and have another route for emergencies
Phone held by retreat staff or support person	Indirectly	Retreat centres and supported formats
Basic phone for calls only	Yes	Readers who want no apps but need emergency access

Option A: Remain reachable for emergencies. Keep cellular service on. Use your phone's Focus or Do Not Disturb setting to silence all apps and people except one or two designated emergency contacts. Disable notification badges and previews, and keep the phone face down or in another part of the room. Most phones allow selected contacts to ring through a silenced

phone, but settings vary and change with updates, so test it before you leave.

Option B: Disconnect completely. Use airplane mode with Wi-Fi turned off. In this arrangement you will not receive ordinary emergency calls. Turn connectivity back on only during a scheduled check, or arrange for emergencies to be routed through the retreat centre, hotel, host, or another nearby person who can reach you physically.

Whichever you choose, **test the arrangement before the retreat.** Ask the designated person to call while the setting is active. Confirm that their call rings and that other notifications remain silent. If it fails, fix it before you go, not on Day 1.

The rest of the arrangement

Before you leave, tell people. Send a short message to the people who normally reach you: family, colleagues, your ministry team, close friends. "I am away from Thursday to Sunday and will not be checking messages. If something urgent comes up, contact [name], who can reach me." That single message removes most of the anxiety, because the people who might need you know what to do, and you know that they know.

Choose one emergency contact and define "emergency." Ideally this is your designated support person, or a family member, who has your location and agrees to contact you only for a genuine emergency. If you have children, the person caring for them is usually the right choice. A genuine emergency may include a serious health or safety problem, an urgent issue involving a dependant, or a situation that cannot reasonably wait until the retreat ends. It does not include ordinary questions, routine work decisions, or matters that someone else can resolve. Adapt the definition to your responsibilities, and say it out loud to the

person so there is no ambiguity. Ask them to call rather than send an ordinary message, and agree on what they should do if you do not answer: call again, contact the retreat property, or leave a message marked urgent.

Deal with the Bible problem. Opening a Bible app on a multifunction device places Scripture beside the same apps that usually compete for your attention. If you can, bring a printed Bible. If you cannot, a phone with notifications disabled and the Bible app open will work, but be honest with yourself about how it goes on Day 1, and switch to paper on Day 2 if it is not working.

The same applies to this guide. If you are reading it as an ebook and your edition and device allow it, print the retreat session pages from Part Three for your personal use. Otherwise, download everything in advance and read on an e-reader or tablet that has no messaging apps, or use a distraction-reducing reading mode. A device limited to the Bible and this guide presents far fewer distractions, though paper still offers the clearest separation.

Leave the other screens off. Television, laptop, tablet with email, smartwatch notifications. If you are at home, unplug the television or put the remote in a drawer. This is not about severity. It is about not having to make the decision fifty times a day.

Avoid publicly narrating the retreat while you are living it. Posting can turn private attention toward audience reaction, and it can expose your location. Communicate necessary safety information privately to trusted people. If you want to share a reflection publicly, wait until you have returned and had time to discern what should remain private.

Prepare the device before you leave

- Download the Bible, this guide, maps, any music, and emergency information for offline use
- Disable notification badges and lock-screen previews
- Remove social-media and email apps from the home screen, or temporarily sign out
- Turn off smartwatch notifications
- Write essential contact details and emergency numbers on paper
- Save the retreat address
- Bring a charger or power bank
- Test the emergency-contact arrangement
- Tell the designated person when the boundary begins and ends

Music, podcasts, and worship

Some readers will want to know whether worship music is allowed. The answer is yes, in a limited way. Part Three will occasionally suggest a song or a period of listening, and if music helps you enter prayer, use it. But the default of the retreat is silence, and I would ask you not to use music to fill every quiet moment. Silence may initially reveal how accustomed you are to constant input. Mild restlessness can be observed without alarm. If silence triggers panic, flashbacks, dissociation, or severe distress, follow Chapter 5's guidance: shorten the period, keep your eyes open, move gently, contact support, or pause the retreat.

For this guided retreat, leave podcasts, sermons, audiobooks, and additional teaching aside unless a session specifically directs you to one. They are valuable in ordinary life, but this program

already provides structured input. The remaining space is for prayer, Scripture, rest, observation, and response.

What to expect when you stop

If you are used to constant connection, the first day without it may feel strange, and it helps to know what is common.

You may reach for the phone without deciding to. This is habit, not weakness, and it may happen many times on Day 1. Each time, notice it, and return to what you were doing.

You may feel a low-level restlessness that has no obvious cause. Restlessness may ease as the retreat continues, though the timing differs from person to person. Some readers will enjoy the separation quickly; others will continue to find it difficult. Neither response determines the spiritual value of the retreat.

You may find that your mind is louder than you expected. Thoughts, worries, memories, and lists that were held down by the constant stream may surface. The return of ordinary thoughts and unfinished concerns is not necessarily a problem; it may simply mean you are noticing what constant input had obscured. Write down what surfaces, and the sessions ahead will give those thoughts somewhere to go. If the experience becomes severe or destabilising, do not interpret that as spiritual progress you must endure. Follow the safety guidance in Chapter 5.

In my pastoral experience, many people later describe the digital boundary as one of the most valuable parts of the retreat, and some choose to keep a version of it afterwards. Part Five will help you think about that.

Adjustments for other formats

One-day retreat. Everything above applies for the day. Tell people, choose your arrangement, and keep it from the moment you begin until you finish.

Three-hour reset. Keep the phone out of sight and block ordinary interruptions. If you must remain reachable for dependants or emergencies, use Option A and allow only the designated contact to ring through.

At-home retreat. This is the hardest format for a digital boundary because ordinary life continues. The realistic version is a boundary around the session time, not the whole week. For each session, put the phone in another room or use Option A for the duration. Between sessions, live normally. Where your responsibilities permit, consider avoiding social media and non-essential news for the week, and keep necessary digital activity deliberate and limited rather than allowing it to spread through the entire day.

A written agreement

It helps to write the boundary down before you go, because a boundary written on paper is easier to keep than one held vaguely in mind. Copy the following into your journal and fill it in:

For my retreat from _____ to _____, I will use the following arrangement (tick one):

- ☐ *Emergency-call option: cellular service remains on, but Focus or Do Not Disturb allows calls only from _____.* ☐ *Scheduled-check option: the phone remains disconnected except for checks at _____.* ☐ *Property-contact option: my emergency contact will*

call _____, who can reach me at the retreat location.

I tested this arrangement on _____.

My emergency contact is _____, and we have agreed what counts as an emergency.

I have told _____, _____, and _____ that I am unavailable.

I will read Scripture on _____ and this guide on _____.

I will not post about the retreat while it is happening.

If I slip, I will put the phone down and return to what I was doing without guilt.

Signed: _____

If you are retreating with a spouse or group, discuss the shared expectations in advance. Each person should state their own boundary and any legitimate exceptions. Encourage one another without monitoring, shaming, or confiscating devices.

Before you turn the page

1. What is your honest reaction to the thought of three days without your phone? Write it down without judging it.
2. Which arrangement are you choosing, who is your emergency contact, and when will you test it?
3. How will you read Scripture and this guide during the retreat? If the answer is "on my phone," what will you do to make that workable?
4. Fill in the written agreement above.

CHAPTER 10

What to Bring

This is the shortest chapter in the book, and it should be. A retreat that needs a great deal of equipment has already become something else. But a few things matter, and forgetting them can cost you an afternoon of driving back for a charger or, more seriously, leave you without medication or a way to call for help. So here is a short, practical list, with a few notes on why each item earns its place.

Near the end of 2 Timothy, while imprisoned, Paul asks Timothy to bring "the cloak that I left with Carpus at Troas, also the books, and above all the parchments" (2 Timothy 4:13). Warmth for his body and written material that mattered to him. Two thousand years later, physical care and attentive reading still belong together.

For the sessions

A Bible. Bring a printed Bible if that is accessible and practical for you, for the reasons Chapter 9 gave. Otherwise, prepare an audio or digital Bible in a way that minimises unrelated notifications and distractions. Bring the translation you are most comfortable reading slowly.

This guide, or the session pages from Part Three. Printed, on an e-reader, or on a device you have prepared according to Chapter

9. Make sure you can read the sessions without walking past your inbox.

A journal and a pen. Handwriting is recommended because it often encourages a slower pace, and a physical journal is one you can bring back and reread. If handwriting is difficult or inaccessible, use an offline document, a voice recorder, a tablet, or another method that allows you to reflect without opening work or communication apps. The purpose is deliberate reflection, not a particular physical method. Choose a journal you will actually use rather than one so beautiful you are afraid to write in it, and bring a spare pen.

Decide, too, how you will keep your journal private, particularly in a shared home, a group retreat, a borrowed property, or a relationship where someone reads your things. Do not write identifying details if doing so could place you or someone else at risk.

The pages you have already written. Your check-in from Chapter 4, your intention from Chapter 7, and anything you wrote about resistance in Chapter 8. Session One will ask for them. Tuck them into the front of the journal.

A simple timer or watch. Several sessions include timed silence, and you should not have to pick up your phone to time it. A cheap kitchen timer or a watch with a timer function will do.

A few index cards or small pieces of paper. A few sessions may invite you to write something that you want to keep separately, tear up, or place in an envelope. Loose cards make this easier.

Optional: something that helps you settle. A small cross or picture, a blanket, a particular mug. A battery-powered candle is the safest kind; use an open-flame candle only where it is explicitly permitted, on a stable surface away from anything

flammable, and never leave it unattended. Avoid candles if smoke, scent, or flickering light causes you physical or emotional discomfort. None of these are spiritual necessities. These familiar objects can help mark the space as intentional and make it easier for some people to settle.

Medication and health

Medication. Bring enough prescribed medication for the retreat and any reasonably foreseeable travel delay, following your prescriber's instructions and any applicable travel rules. Keep it labelled and stored at the required temperature. Bring necessary prescriptions, administration supplies, or medical devices. Do not alter doses, stop medication, or change your usual schedule for the retreat or for a fast without medical advice.

Essential medical information. Carry it where emergency responders can find it, while protecting unnecessary personal details. Include serious allergies, conditions relevant to emergency care, and essential medication information. If your phone's emergency medical information is accessible from the lock screen, set it up.

Accessibility aids and medical equipment. Bring any aids, devices, and supplies you normally rely on: glasses or lenses, hearing aids and their batteries, mobility aids, a CPAP machine, glucose-monitoring or insulin supplies, an EpiPen, braces or supports. A retreat is not the time to prove that you can manage without them.

Clothing and sleep

Comfortable clothes in layers. You will sit still for long periods, which makes people cold, and you will walk, which makes them warm. Bring what suits the season and the location, plus one layer more than you think you need.

Shoes you can walk in. Several sessions suggest walking, and the outdoors is part of the retreat where it is possible.

Whatever you need to sleep well. Chapter 6 said that rest is part of the retreat. If you sleep better with your own pillow, earplugs, or an eye mask, bring them. If you use prescribed sleep medication or a CPAP machine, maintain your normal routine. Do not experiment with unfamiliar sleep aids during the retreat.

For outdoors. Sunscreen, a hat, insect repellent, rain protection, and a small first-aid kit if you will be walking away from buildings. Carry only supplies you know how to use, remain within your physical ability, and tell your support person where you are walking. Check the weather before you leave, not when you arrive.

Personal care

Toothbrush and toothpaste, soap, deodorant, a towel if one is not provided, menstrual products, and whatever else you use daily. It is easy to forget the ordinary things when you are thinking about the spiritual ones.

Food and water

Chapter 11 is about this in more detail. For now: bring food that meets your dietary, allergy, medical, and medication needs, and choose simple things that need little preparation. Confirm whether a shared kitchen or retreat centre can safely accommodate serious allergies. Do not begin an unfamiliar restrictive diet during the retreat. Bring adequate drinking water or confirm that safe water is available, and do not restrict water as part of this retreat. If a medical condition or medication affects your fluid needs, follow professional advice.

Safety, communication, and transport

Your phone, prepared as Chapter 9 described, with the emergency arrangement tested and the charger packed. A power bank if you will be away from sockets.

A paper card with essential information. The address of where you are staying, the name and number of your emergency contact, the number of the property or host, your doctor's number, and the emergency services number for the country you are in. If your phone fails, this card is your backup.

Identification and any documents the location requires. A booking confirmation, a key code, the name of the person who let you use the house.

Cash or a card, for food, transport, or an unexpected need. Not much, but not nothing.

Transport in both directions. Confirm how you will arrive and how you will leave. Keep enough money, fuel, battery charge, or a backup contact to return safely. Do not drive if you are severely distressed, unwell, or too tired to do so safely.

Location-specific items

Before you pack, confirm whether the location provides bedding and towels, food-preparation equipment, heating or cooling, drinking water, toiletries, and keys or entry codes. This prevents both overpacking and arriving without something you assumed would be there.

What to leave behind

This list is as important as the other one.

Work. Leave work devices behind unless a device is necessary for accessibility, Scripture, this guide, or emergency communication.

If you must bring one, download what you need, sign out of work accounts, and keep it offline during sessions. The retreat has room for you to think about your work, and one of the Day 3 sessions will ask you to. It does not have room for you to do it.

Unfinished projects. Finish, delegate, or reschedule genuinely time-sensitive responsibilities before leaving, including next Sunday's sermon if that is yours to give. Do not bring ordinary projects merely because the quiet setting might help you complete them.

Most other books. This may seem strange from someone who writes them. Keep additional reading minimal. If your retreat practice requires a hymnal, a prayer book, or one carefully chosen companion text, bring it deliberately. Do not pack a stack of books to protect yourself from silence.

Objects that create unnecessary pressure. Leave behind items that predictably trigger guilt, compulsive work, distress, or a sense that you must perform for someone else. Bring photographs or meaningful objects only if they support the purpose of the retreat and feel emotionally safe. If a session needs you to bring a memory into the room, it will say so.

Name the guilt about leaving. If guilt returns while you pack, reread Chapter 2 and write down what the guilt is saying. You do not need to eliminate the feeling before you go; you only need to keep it from making the decision for you.

A checklist

Copy this and tick it off before you leave. Items marked (optional) are just that.

Sessions and reflection

- Bible, printed or prepared

WHAT TO BRING

- This guide or the Part Three session pages
- Journal (or accessible alternative) and two pens
- Chapter 4 check-in, Chapter 7 intention, Chapter 8 notes
- Timer or watch
- Index cards or loose paper
- Settling object (optional) **Medication and health**
- All regular medication, with extra
- Prescriptions, supplies, or devices
- Essential medical information, accessible in an emergency
- Accessibility aids and medical equipment **Clothing and sleep**
- Layered clothes for the season
- Walking shoes
- Pillow, earplugs, eye mask (optional)
- Outdoor items: sunscreen, hat, repellent, rain protection, first-aid kit **Personal care and accessibility**
- Toothbrush, toothpaste, soap, deodorant
- Towel, if not provided
- Menstrual products, if needed
- Glasses, contact-lens supplies, hearing-aid batteries **Food and water**
- Simple food meeting your needs (see Chapter 11)
- Refillable water bottle **Safety, communication, and transport**
- Phone, prepared and tested
- Charger and power bank
- Paper card: address, emergency contact, host, doctor, emergency number
- Identification and booking details
- Cash or card
- Transport confirmed both ways **Location-specific**

- Bedding and towels, if not provided
- Cooking equipment, if self-catering
- Keys or entry code **Leave behind**
- Work and work devices
- Unfinished projects (completed, delegated, or rescheduled)
- Extra books
- Objects that create pressure
- Guilt acknowledged and addressed using Chapter 2

Before you turn the page

1. Go through the checklist and mark anything you do not yet have. Which missing items are essential? Will you buy, borrow, substitute, download, or decide that you do not need them?
2. Is there anything on the "leave behind" list you are reluctant to leave? Write down what it is and what you are afraid will happen if you do not bring it.